

Transhumanism:

The next step in evolution?

If people really can turn in their graves, Darwin would probably be doing somersaults

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“**T**ranshumanism is a class of philosophies of life that seek the continuation and acceleration of the evolution of intelligent life beyond its currently human form and human limitations by means of science and technology, guided by life-promoting principles and values.”
 – **Max More**, 1990

Considering that the definition was coined two decades ago, it's probably safe to assume that Transhumanism is not really a new concept. But it has certainly been gaining traction with time. And probably with good reason too - if there is a new direction that we think we should be going in, this is probably the time to decide. Here, we take it upon ourselves to make sure you're in the loop on this, because it might be a genuine fork in the road, in the near future. So what really is transhumanism? Well, for starters, it is...

More than just a fancy word

A campaign pioneered by the Humanity+ community (formerly the World Transhumanist Association), it is a movement to essentially garner support for the prospect of allowing us humans to take to technology to overcome all that we consider to be wrong with the human 'condition'. Started 1998 by a couple of philosophers, Nick Bostrom and David Pearce, they are not the only proponents of the use of technology. But unlike the solely utopian visions of its now defunct 'competitor'

the Extropy Institute, Humanity+ actually understands that social dynamics of the issue are of equal, if not more concern here. That is why they are considered the better representatives of the movement that is transhumanism. Like any other pseudo-support group, they have their own magazine, the 'h+', and they hold annual TransVision conferences at exotic locations. Whatever heavy vocabulary the Humanity+ website may throw at you, the



A vision to reach our full potential

essence remains that they are the people who are making the moves to make this world home to the Terminators and Robocops that we've only known on the silver screen as of yet. We are not complaining.

Their declaration of the cause says that they think that the full power that the human form has in itself has not been harnessed efficiently yet, and that technology is the key to unlocking that potential. Their aim is to "broaden the human potential" by infusing into our very structure, developments from various fields of science, ranging from present technologies such as biotechnology and information technology, and anticipated future technologies, such as molecular nanotechnology and artificial general intelligence.

The work done is aimed at overcoming aging, cognitive shortcomings, involuntary suffering, and rather unsurprisingly, our confinement to planet Earth. Hell, for a while now executives at Humanity+ have been known to get chips implanted in their bodies to make doors open automatically for them. A minor feat, sure, but in the end, it's really about what you want from this, because, clichéd as it may sound, the possibilities probably are endless. In addition to lobbying to get their chain of thought into the mainstream public thinking, they also claim to be doing extensive studies about some of the raging issues that such a promise would spawn immediately. Studies range from singularity research to the (very real) fear of extinction. While they're really just asking permission to begin making cyborgs, the idea is not a new one in itself. Humans have, from times immemorial, believed themselves to be supremely powerful and capable (and good looking). They've believed that any task that is beyond them is not because they're not up to it, it's because they haven't figured out the solution yet. And this is the single most important quality that we possess as a race - resilience. It might just be the chief reason that we've achieved so, so much in

TRANSHUMAN & POSTHUMAN

Now this is where the lines of definiteness blur, and ideas get hazy. A transhuman can broadly be defined as somebody/something that is on its way to posthumanism, but is still sufficiently identifiable with the human condition. A posthuman is everything we're not. A form of life that so exceedingly bests anything that we mere humans have to offer, that it simply cannot be called human at all. The proper definition even states that posthumans might constitute conscious artificial intelligence. Woah, trippy!